

The Dance School Awards: Industry Award - Dance School of the Year

Dance School of the Year Application / Nomination Questions.

Please find below 5 questions which we will need you to answer to proceed with your nomination.

Judges will consider:

- Clear, specific achievements from the past year and why they matter.
- Evidence of positive impact on students, staff, or the wider community.
- A clearly articulated ethos and set of values.
- Thoughtful support for students with different goals and pathways.
- Clear safeguarding procedures embedded in everyday practice.
- Awareness of student wellbeing and duty of care.
- Evidence of commitment to equity, diversity, and inclusion in policies, practice, and culture.
- Strong leadership and professional standards.
- A compelling overall case for why the school stands out.

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Fundamentalz Dance

1. Tell us 3 things you are most proud of your school achieving in the last year. *

1. Growing the school and our competition squad

Over the past year, we have expanded into new areas, added more classes and welcomed more young people into the school. This has also helped us grow our competition squad and give more dancers the chance to compete.

Seven of our dancers won British solo titles at SDI International this year, while 47 have qualified for the UDO World Championships across teams, battles, solos, duos and trio/quad categories. Two of our youngest battlers were also invited as guests to major youth competitions.

We are proud that dancers at different stages are progressing, from young beginners entering their first battles to experienced dancers competing internationally.

2. Developing our hip hop theatre work

We have continued to create original hip hop theatre pieces and give our dancers more chances to perform outside competitions.

For the second year running, we represented Bedfordshire at U.Dance East and were shortlisted for the national festival. We were also selected for platforms including Dancers Delight U18 and RE.

This work brings dancers of different ages together and helps them develop teamwork, creativity, expression and performance skills.

3. Setting up Fundamentalz Performing Arts CIC

This year, we established Fundamentalz Performing Arts CIC to bring hip hop theatre and wider creative opportunities to more young people.

The CIC will run performance companies, create original stage work and work with schools and community groups. It will also help us offer subsidised and fully funded places where cost may be a barrier.

We want young people to experience the wider hip hop culture, not just dance. Over time, we plan to include areas such as DJing, MCing and graffiti art, giving them more ways to learn and be creative.

2. How would you describe your school's ethos and values? *

Our ethos and values are based on authenticity, progression and community.

We want young people to understand that hip hop and street dance are established dance forms with their own history, foundations and culture. Our dancers learn where the styles come from, rather than simply learning moves and routines.

Respect is a big part of that culture. Hip hop and battles are built around recognising other people's talent and individuality, and we try to instil that in every student from the moment they join. We want dancers to be confident in their own style while also supporting others.

We believe every dancer should be able to progress from their own starting point. For some, that means confidence, friendships and enjoying a weekly class. For others, it means competitions, performances or professional training. Both are as important.

We also expect hard work and commitment. Dancers are encouraged to listen to feedback and understand that progress takes time.

Most importantly, we want Fundamentalz to be a community where young people and their families feel safe, supported and proud to belong.

3. How do you support both recreational and aspiring professional students? *

We offer different routes because not every dancer wants the same experience.

Our recreational classes focus on foundations, enjoyment, confidence and creativity. Dancers can train without competing, with performances available as an option.

Those who want to take things further can audition for competition teams, theatre projects and advanced pieces, with more focused training and regular feedback.

Our Performing Arts CIC provides another route through hip hop theatre and original performance work. As a not-for-profit organisation, it will also help us offer subsidised and funded places.

We encourage ambitious dancers to train outside Fundamentalz, learn from different teachers and experience the wider dance community. Some also study other dance styles at different schools.

Our founder, Mia Beaney, is a member of Boy Blue and has trained and performed with IMD Legion and Flawless. She uses that experience to give honest advice about professional training and has supported several dancers through successful Boy Blue auditions. Older students can also assist, mentor, choreograph and teach.

We understand that ambitions change, so dancers can move between competitive and recreational routes and still feel there is a place for them at Fundamentalz.

4. What does safe guarding and student wellbeing look like in practice at your school? *

Safeguarding and wellbeing are part of how we run the school every day.

We have a named safeguarding lead, written policies and clear reporting procedures. Senior staff hold Enhanced DBS certificates, first-aid qualifications and chaperone licences.

We have clear rules around communication, supervision, physical contact and the use of photographs and videos. Communication with younger dancers goes through parents or approved group channels, and teachers receive the medical and additional-needs information they require.

We also have a growing number of neurodivergent students, as well as neurodivergent teachers. We are not specialist providers, but this experience helps us understand that dancers may learn and communicate differently. We work with families and adapt our teaching where possible so dancers feel included and supported.

In class, we use proper warm-ups, age-appropriate training and safe progression of skills. Dancers are encouraged to speak up about injuries or anything making them uncomfortable.

We know competitions can create pressure. Feedback is constructive, comparisons are discouraged and we celebrate progress at every level, whether that means winning a title or finding the confidence to step onto the floor.

We want every student to feel safe, respected and supported, and we deal with concerns quickly when they arise.

5. Why do you believe your school deserves this award? *

I started Fundamentalz at 16 because I wanted young people locally to have opportunities that I had needed to travel to London to find.

Five years later, the school has grown much further than I imagined. We now support recreational dancers, international competitors, theatre performers and young people beginning to teach and choreograph.

We have achieved some brilliant results, but I am just as proud of the confidence, friendships and sense of belonging our dancers and families have built.

We care about teaching street dance properly. Our students learn the foundations and culture behind the styles, while also developing their own creativity and identity.

Setting up Fundamentalz Performing Arts CIC is our next step. It will help us reach more young people, reduce financial barriers and bring wider hip hop culture into our local communities.

I believe Fundamentalz deserves this award because we are building something ambitious, but also something that matters to the young people and families involved.

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